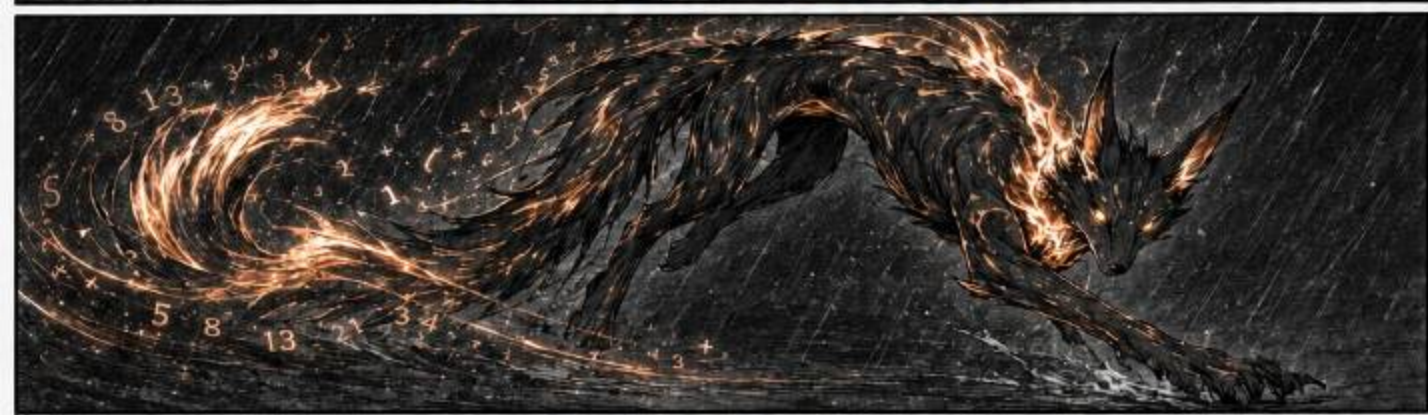


Four.

Twelve.

Thirty-six.

A hundred and eight.







You're staring.



That was $\times 3$.
Four solves,
no drops.
Anyone can do it.



Not everyone
does.





SOJUTSU-SPIRITS

Phase One: the Edgemost Road.



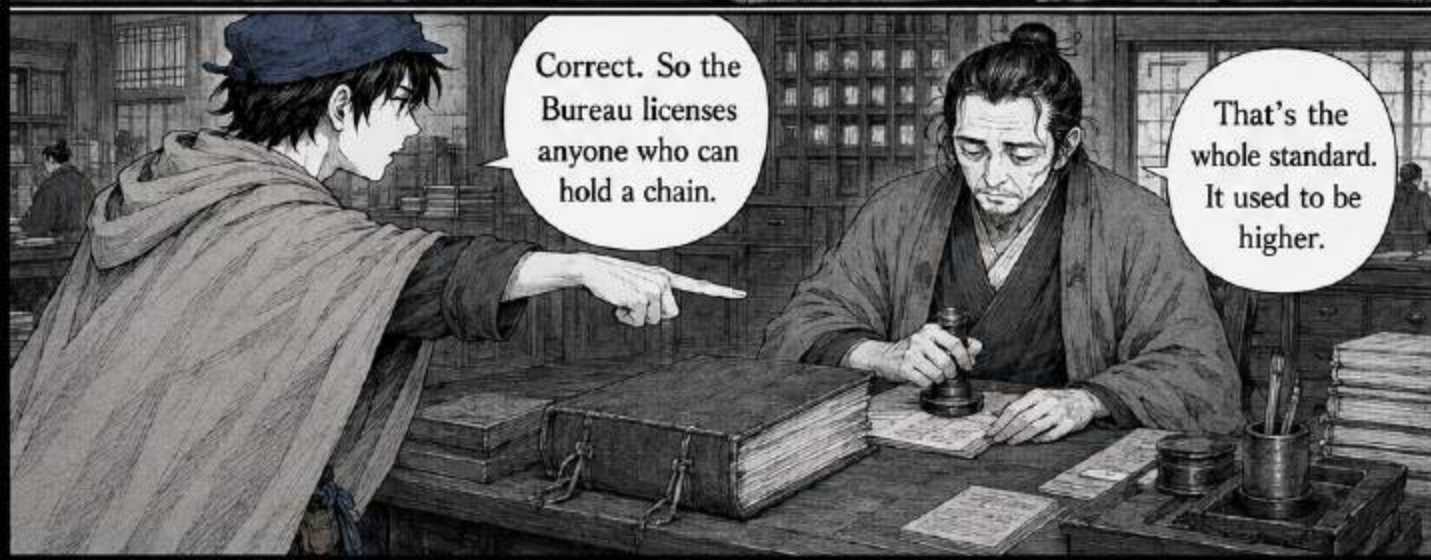


Name. Age.
Grade.



Ungraded.
Right.







Your grandmother's.
Three sealed. Pick one,
sign here, don't die.



Next.





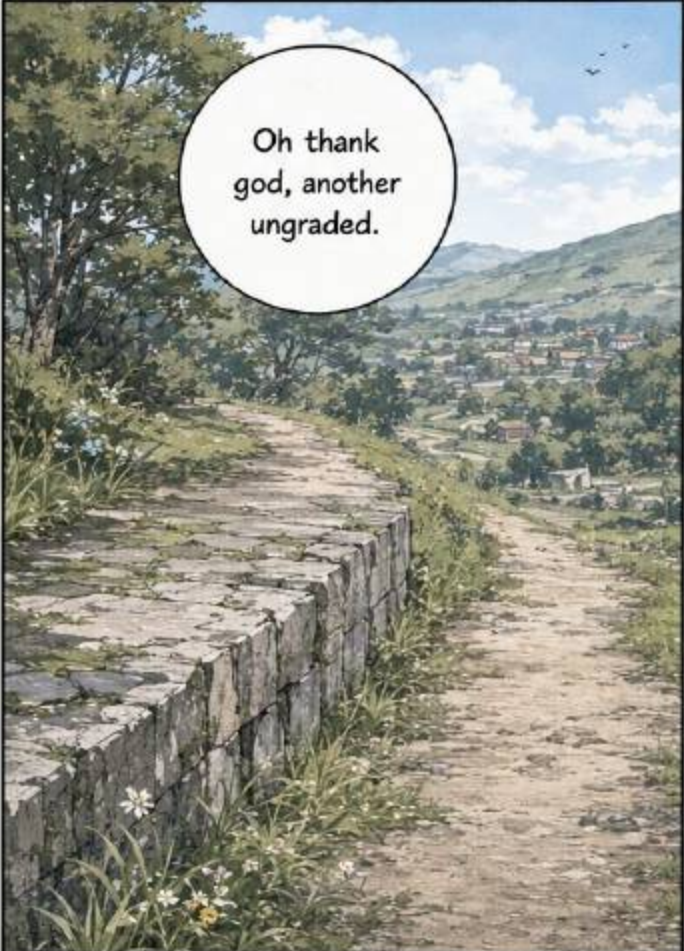
Signed,
then.

Your grandmother
was Grade 6. Did he
tell you that?

No. They
never do.

Go on.
I'll keep the
other two.





Oh thank
god, another
ungraded.



Everyone
on this road
is Sigil-1-and-up
and acts like it.



Watch —
chain is just
don't stop.

The hard part
is not panicking
when the timer
bar moves.









You're the new one. Sit down, you're blocking my light.



Three hundred years back, a binder took that thing down. Four days of solid chain.



Four days. Think about that.





Then she couldn't move it. So they buried it and planted taro on top.









Two routes up.
One's short.
One's clear.



Pick wrong and
you'll be past your
depth before you
want to be.



◇ 十 卐 卐 卐 卐 ×1.5



Good.
Your chain held
past six.



Somebody used
to sweep this
grove daily.
Kept it thin.

They stopped.
Nobody remembers
ordering that.



Fight me
if you want.
Look up first.



That's not a hunt.
Hunting isn't *regular*.



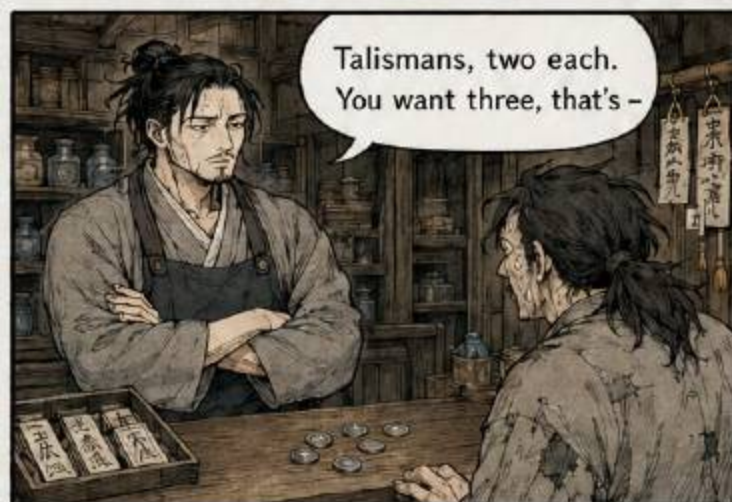
Something's
measuring itself.
Every year.
Against the
same trees.



Same claw.
Three heights.
Even spacing.

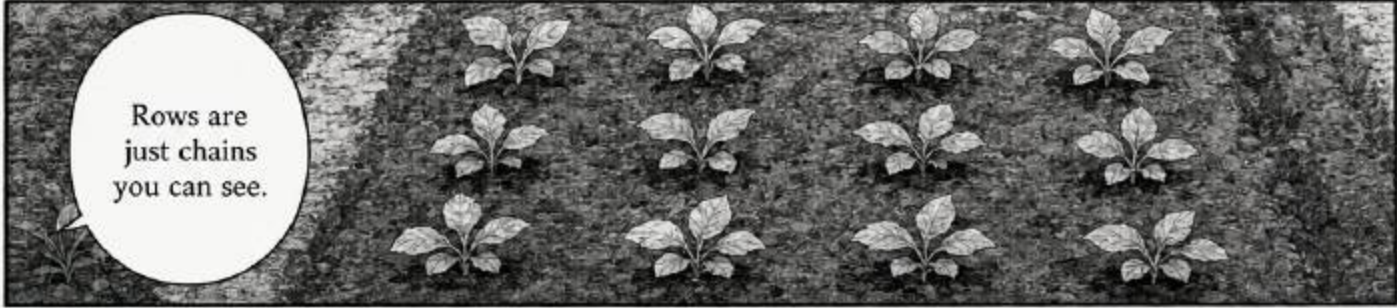


Bureau's had
that report four
times. It's still
a report.





Three rows.
Four in each.
Don't count
them one at a
time, that's
what beginners do.



Rows are
just chains
you can see.



I cut seals.
Wrong shape,
wrong bind,
dead binder.



Which of
these is a
cylinder.



You'd be
amazed how
many Sigil-2s
get that wrong
at speed.





Ungraded.
Walked past
four of my
wardens.

Fine.

LEAFLARK.

$$\begin{array}{r} 5 \\ + 3 \\ \hline 8 \times 1.5 \end{array}$$

There it is.
That's Cadence.
Hold it.

$$\begin{array}{r} 13 \\ + 5 \\ \hline 18 \times 1.5 \end{array} \quad \begin{array}{r} 21 \\ + 8 \\ \hline 29 \times 1.5 \end{array} \quad \begin{array}{r} 34 \\ + 13 \\ \hline 47 \times 1.5 \end{array} \quad \begin{array}{r} 55 \\ + 21 \\ \hline 76 \times 1.5 \end{array} \quad \begin{array}{r} 89 \\ + 34 \\ \hline 123 \times 1.5 \end{array} \quad \begin{array}{r} 144 \\ + 55 \\ \hline 199 \times 1.5 \end{array}$$





Hold on.

First-sigils
through this gate
this season: four.

First-sigils
through this gate
this season:
|||||

Bodies
through this gate:
||||||

Bodies through
this gate: five.







Don't touch
the wall.

156

78

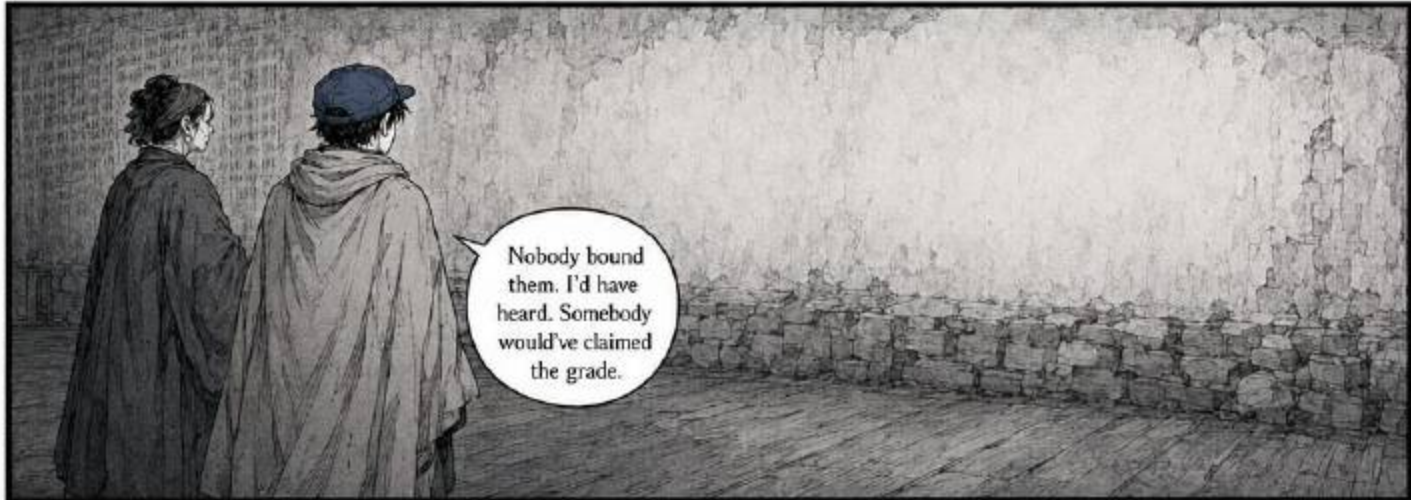


156 marks.
Then 78 more
before they
stopped. Total?

234



234 sightings.
Then nothing.
Four hundred
days of nothing.



Nobody bound
them. I'd have
heard. Somebody
would've claimed
the grade.











456 incidents.
The 5 there —
what's it worth.



fifty

Fifty. Not five.
People get that
wrong and
misfile by a
factor of ten.



TEN YEARS AGO

NOW

Ten years ago
this column was
half as long.

I file it
annually. The
form has no
reply field.
Make of that
what you like.







Sigil 2. Ferry
licence with it.



Ranting sent you
with the question in
your mouth. He does
that.



Yes — six shrines,
six sleepers. One each.
That's the arrangement.



We don't hold them
down. Nobody could.
They're *settled*.



Settled things stay.
That's the entire
load-bearing
assumption of
the Bureau.









Past here
the roof's held
up by something
that isn't timber.

Silk. Went hard
as stone a long
time back. Harder
than the rock.

87 props,
4 galleries.
How do I
split them.

21 each,
3 spare

21 each, 3 spare.
The spare three
are why I'm
still alive.

It's under here.
Been under here
my whole life.
My father's too.

Never done
a thing. That's
not the same
as gone.

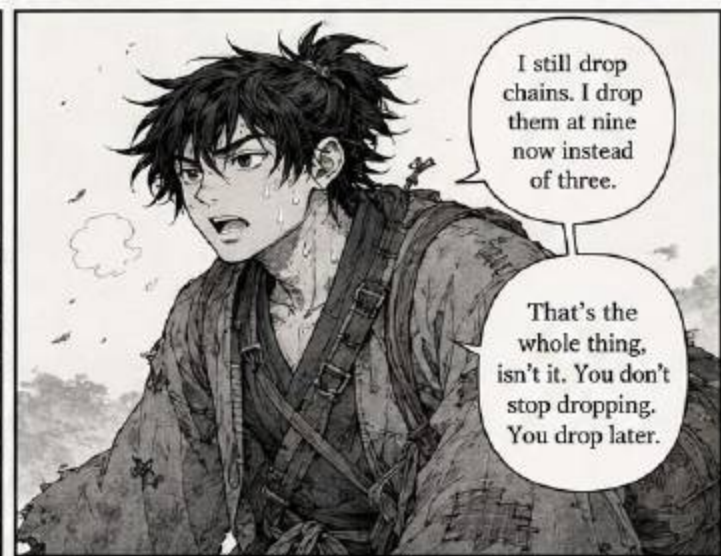


You want
to know about
the gate.



It's sigil-locked.
It's not *guard*-locked.





1



2



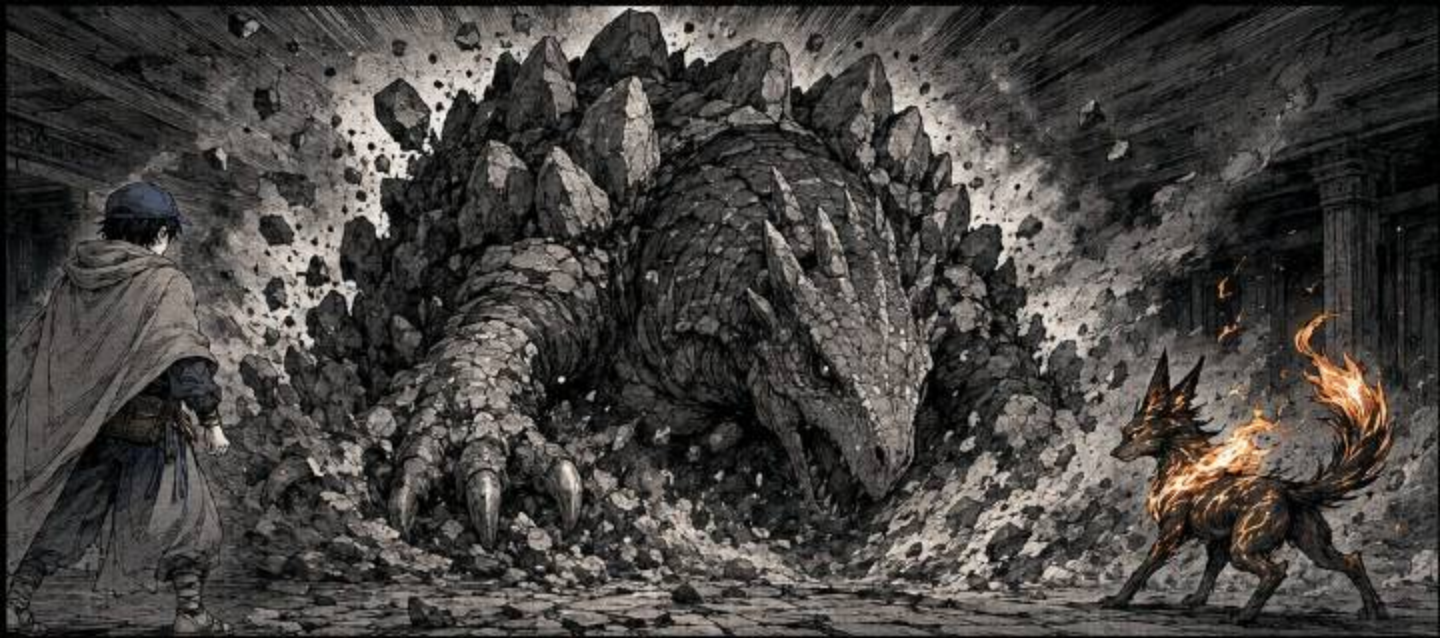
3



4





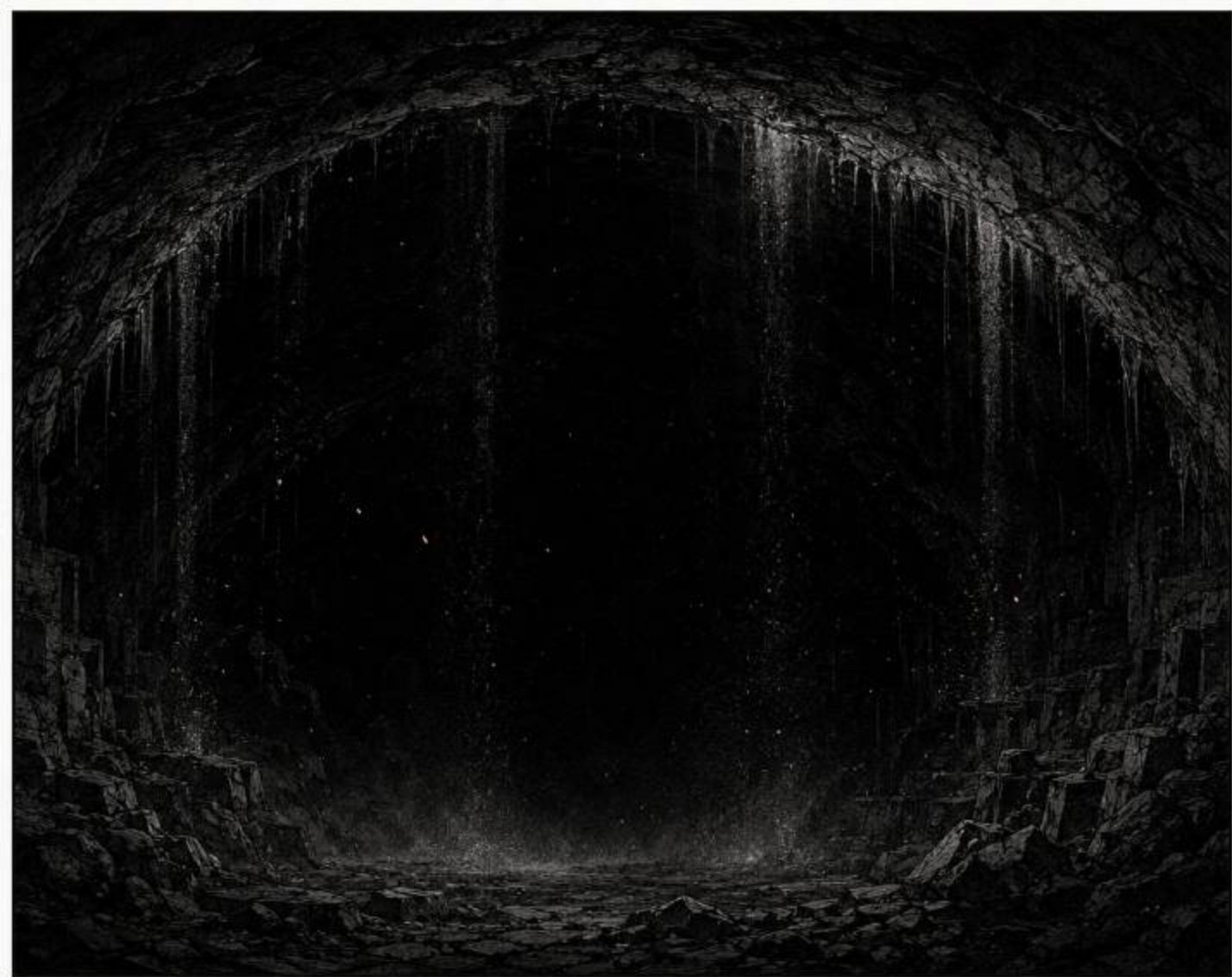
















...Five
accounted for.



I only
checked the
ones I could see.



PHASE ONE — END.
The road stays open.